NCE EXAM PREP

Practice Exam 21

Domain 3

Treatment Planning & Continuity of Care

26 Practice Questions | 34 minutes

A, B, C answer choices

Answer Key and Explanations included

> **Instructions.** Select the single best answer for each question. Record your answers separately. This domain practice set is drawn from Full-Length Practice Exam 04. Use the suggested 34-minute practice timer. Do not consult Part B until you complete Part A. These domain timings are editorial practice allocations, not official NBCC section limits.

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PART A — QUESTIONS

Choose one answer (A, B, or C) per question.

Question 1

> Two adolescent siblings are referred to the same substance-use counseling group. One sibling says the other's presence would prevent honest discussion about family and substance use. An equivalent group at a different time is available.

Which modality decision is most appropriate?

A) Enroll both siblings together because shared family context will improve accountability

B) Require a trial session together before considering whether privacy affects participation

C) Arrange separate groups or another suitable format so each sibling can participate candidly

Question 2

Why is a baseline useful when writing a measurable treatment objective?

A) It establishes the starting level against which progress toward the target can be compared

B) It guarantees that the selected intervention will produce the expected amount of change

C) It determines which diagnosis should be assigned before the objective is implemented

Question 3

> An older adult seeks counseling because of worry about memory decline after the death of a spouse. Recent medical and cognitive evaluations found no evidence of a neurocognitive disorder. The client reports sleeping four hours nightly, withdrawing from friends, and repeatedly checking for forgotten tasks.

Which initial plan best integrates the available findings?

A) Address bereavement, sleep, social withdrawal, and checking while monitoring whether memory concerns change

B) Begin cognitive rehabilitation because subjective memory worry is sufficient evidence of cognitive impairment

C) Avoid planning until another cognitive evaluation can establish a neurological explanation

Question 4

A client experiencing caregiver stress provides daily care for a parent with dementia and has stopped attending counseling because no relief coverage is available. The client wants to resume care and agrees to referrals for caregiver support and respite services.

Which response best addresses the continuity barrier?

A) Recommend more frequent counseling before making referrals because caregiver stress is the primary concern

B) Advise the client to ask family members for help before using formal community resources

C) Connect the client with verified respite and caregiver services and coordinate access with permission

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Question 5

A client in assertiveness counseling performs skills accurately during role-plays but has not attempted the agreed conversation with a roommate. The original termination criterion includes independent use of an assertive request in a real relationship.

How should readiness for termination be evaluated?

A) Terminate because accurate role-play demonstrates mastery of the skill

B) Continue weekly counseling indefinitely because real-world attempts can never be predicted

C) Plan a supported real-world attempt and review the result against the agreed criterion before deciding

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Question 6

A parent in counseling wants a consistent bedtime routine for a child but has parenting time only three nights each week. The other parent is not participating in counseling and has not agreed to use the same routine. The client can reliably control what happens during the client's own parenting time.

Which objective is most attainable?

A) The client will implement and track a consistent routine during the three weekly parenting nights for one month

B) Both households will use the identical routine every night beginning this week

C) The client will postpone the bedtime goal until the other parent agrees to participate

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Question 7

A Black client reports repeated racial discrimination at work and says a previous counselor treated the resulting vigilance as irrational. The client wants counseling to address emotional strain and to consider practical workplace responses without being pushed toward a formal complaint.

Which plan is most responsive to the client's stated context?

A) Focus only on reducing vigilance because counseling should not incorporate workplace experiences

B) Include client-chosen coping and advocacy options while recognizing discrimination as a relevant stressor

C) Make filing a formal complaint the first objective because advocacy is necessary for treatment progress

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Question 8

A client with well-managed attention-deficit/hyperactivity disorder seeks counseling after the sudden death of a close friend. The client reports grief-related sleep disruption but no current change in attention symptoms or medication management.

How should the diagnosis inform the initial plan?

A) Make attention training the first goal because every established diagnosis must be actively treated

B) Center the current grief and sleep concerns while retaining relevant ADHD supports if they affect goal attainment

C) Remove ADHD from consideration entirely because it is not the reason the client requested counseling

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Question 9

A flood closes a community clinic for at least two weeks and displaces some clients. The agency's disaster plan permits secure contact from an alternate site and lists regional crisis and referral resources. Client locations and service needs may have changed.

Which response best implements continuity planning?

A) Send one detailed message naming all active clients so community agencies can locate them quickly

B) Use approved secure contacts to confirm each client's location and needs, then arrange proportionate alternatives and crisis access

C) Wait until the building reopens because contacting clients from another site could create confusion

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Question 10

A client has met the goals of brief counseling for examination stress, and the current session was planned as the last. Near the end of the session, the client discloses a recent bereavement and asks whether counseling should continue for this new concern.

What is the most appropriate response?

A) End as planned because a new concern cannot be considered after termination criteria are met

B) Extend the existing plan automatically because any new concern prevents appropriate termination

C) Clarify the new need and collaboratively decide whether to open a revised episode of care or arrange another resource

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Question 11

A recently retired client identifies loneliness and wants to develop local social connections. The client is interested in a neighborhood gardening club that meets weekly but is uncertain whether it will feel comfortable.

Which objective is most specific and measurable?

A) The client will become less lonely by developing several meaningful friendships soon

B) The client will attend two gardening-club meetings within four weeks and record one interaction after each

C) The counselor will identify social activities and encourage the client to participate when ready

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Question 12

A client with long COVID has limited daily energy and wants both to resume college courses and to participate more consistently in a child's evening routine. Attempting both at full intensity has led to several days of exhaustion. The client identifies parenting as the more immediate value but does not want to abandon the education goal.

Which initial plan best supports collaborative prioritization?

A) Prioritize college enrollment because education is more likely to improve long-term financial stability

B) Begin with a modest parenting objective, track energy use, and schedule review of readiness for the education goal

C) Assign full objectives for parenting and college so the client can determine which goal succeeds first

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Question 13

A client reviewing a treatment plan says that phrases such as “improve affect regulation” are confusing and do not describe what the client wants to change. The client can clearly describe the desired outcome as pausing before responding during disagreements.

How should the counselor revise the plan?

A) Keep the clinical wording because treatment records should use professional terminology rather than client language

B) Rewrite the goal in clear shared language and add observable signs of pausing before responding

C) Remove the goal because the client cannot independently understand the original technical phrase

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Question 14

A client's treatment goal has focused on managing conflict with a supervisor. The client is unexpectedly laid off when the employer closes, and now reports grief, financial worry, and uncertainty about future work. The previous supervisor-conflict objective is no longer applicable.

What is the best plan revision?

A) Close the obsolete objective and collaboratively establish goals that address the transition and current priorities

B) Keep the original objective active because treatment goals should not change in response to external events

C) End counseling because the disappearance of the workplace conflict resolves the presenting problem

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Question 15

A commercial fisher spends three weeks at sea followed by one week ashore. Internet and privacy are unreliable during voyages, but the client wants counseling for anxiety and can use agreed offline materials. There is no current need for a higher level of care.

Which treatment format best fits the client's circumstances?

A) Require weekly video sessions at sea because regular frequency should take precedence over work conditions

B) Schedule focused sessions while ashore and create offline practice and support plans for each voyage

C) Defer all counseling until the client changes to employment with continuous connectivity

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Question 16

Which arrangement most reduces duplication when several providers participate in a client's care?

A) Each provider develops an independent plan so that professional judgment is not influenced by other services

B) The team defines shared outcomes, provider roles, communication permissions, and a lead coordination responsibility

C) The client carries messages between providers because this avoids the need to clarify professional roles

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Question 17

A client is completing a time-limited social skills group and wants to practice gains through volunteer work at an animal shelter. The client can name the skills learned but is unsure how to respond if avoidance returns after the group ends.

Which aftercare plan best supports generalization?

A) Recommend waiting several months before volunteering so the group gains can stabilize without new demands

B) Identify specific volunteer behaviors, a self-monitoring method, and criteria for contacting a counselor if avoidance increases

C) Arrange for the former group leader to attend the volunteer shifts until the client feels fully confident

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Question 18

A client treated for depressed mood reports loud snoring, morning headaches, and severe daytime sleepiness. Counseling attendance is consistent, but concentration and energy have not improved. The client has not discussed these symptoms with a medical provider and agrees that evaluation may be useful.

Which plan best supports appropriate concurrent care?

A) Suspend counseling until a medical provider determines whether the mood symptoms are psychological

B) Continue counseling without referral because sleep symptoms are outside the treatment plan

C) Encourage timely medical evaluation while continuing to address the client's counseling goals and coordinating with permission

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Question 19

When a client must temporarily pause regular counseling but intends to return, which plan best supports continuity?

A) Identify interim supports and responsibilities, specify necessary information exchange, and set criteria or a date for resuming care

B) Close the case immediately because any outside service automatically replaces the original counselor's role

C) Leave the arrangement informal so the client can decide later which provider is responsible for each need

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Question 20

A client's medication-management clinic announces an immediate closure. The client has ten days of prescribed medication remaining, wants to continue counseling, and asks for help locating a new prescriber. The counselor has an updated referral list but does not prescribe medication.

Which response best supports continuity within the counselor's role?

A) Help confirm a timely prescriber appointment, provide urgent-care options, and continue counseling within scope

B) Recommend changing the medication schedule so the remaining supply lasts until a routine appointment is available

C) Pause counseling because mental health treatment cannot continue without the original medication clinic

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Question 21

A 9-year-old has followed a morning routine on four of five school days for six weeks using a token system. The child now completes most steps without prompts, and the caregiver wants the behavior to continue without permanent reliance on tokens.

How should the behavioral plan be revised?

A) Stop all reinforcement immediately because the target has been met for more than a month

B) Continue the same token schedule indefinitely because any reduction risks losing progress

C) Gradually thin the token schedule, strengthen natural reinforcement, and continue monitoring the routine

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Question 22

A client seeking help for panic attacks sleeps about four hours nightly and consumes five energy drinks most days. Assessment indicates that panic symptoms occur both after heavy caffeine use and in situations unrelated to caffeine. The client wants to reduce attacks and is willing to address sleep and stimulant use.

Which initial plan best integrates these findings?

A) Treat caffeine and sleep as the complete explanation and postpone all panic-focused work

B) Ignore caffeine and sleep because panic also occurs when the client has not used energy drinks

C) Combine gradual sleep and caffeine objectives with appropriate panic treatment and ongoing symptom tracking

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Question 23

A client delays starting important paperwork because avoidance brings immediate relief, then experiences greater anxiety near each deadline. The client has insight into the pattern but continues to postpone tasks.

Which plan most directly addresses the maintaining process?

A) Continue exploring the origins of perfectionism without assigning any observable task behavior

B) Require completion of the entire paperwork packet in one sitting to prevent further avoidance

C) Use brief scheduled starts, track relief and later anxiety, and reinforce completion of defined sections

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Question 24

A client authorizes a vocational rehabilitation coordinator to receive appointment dates and attendance status. The coordinator later asks the counselor for symptom details and treatment goals, and the client says that sharing some additional information may be helpful.

What should the counselor do before expanding coordination?

A) Share the requested details because the existing authorization names the coordinator

B) Refuse any future coordination because the initial authorization cannot be changed

C) Review the requested information with the client and update the authorization if the client agrees

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Question 25

How should a treatment plan use an identified barrier to goal attainment?

A) Translate the barrier into a change in sequencing, support, access, or intervention when relevant

B) Record the barrier as evidence that the client is resistant to the counseling process

C) Remove the goal whenever any barrier makes progress slower than originally expected

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Question 26

> A rural client's only bus route to the counseling clinic is discontinued. The client has a reliable telephone and a private room at home, and agency policy permits telephone sessions when clinically suitable. The client wants to continue while exploring new transportation.

Which interim plan best preserves access?

A) Confirm that telephone care remains suitable, update remote-session procedures, and use it while transportation alternatives are explored

B) Place treatment on hold because telephone sessions cannot be part of an outpatient continuity plan

C) Ask the client to use a public location near the clinic so that the original in-person schedule can continue

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PART B — ANSWER KEY AND EXPLANATIONS

Answers match the numbered items in Part A.

Question 1 — Correct: C

Correct Answer: Arrange separate groups or another suitable format so each sibling can participate candidly

Explanation: The sibling's presence is a specific barrier to honest participation, and an equivalent alternative is available. Requiring joint participation or a trial disclosure session would ignore the identified modality concern.

Question 2 — Correct: A

Correct Answer: It establishes the starting level against which progress toward the target can be compared

Explanation: A baseline makes the amount and direction of change interpretable when the objective is reviewed. It does not guarantee treatment response or independently establish a diagnosis.

Question 3 — Correct: A

Correct Answer: Address bereavement, sleep, social withdrawal, and checking while monitoring whether memory concerns change

Explanation: The available evaluations do not support cognitive impairment, while several treatable factors may intensify subjective memory worry. The plan can address those supported concerns and monitor change without inventing a neurological treatment need.

Question 4 — Correct: C

Correct Answer: Connect the client with verified respite and caregiver services and coordinate access with permission

Explanation: Lack of relief coverage is the concrete barrier preventing counseling attendance, so an actionable respite referral directly supports continuity. Increasing counseling frequency without solving access or requiring informal family help first would not address the stated obstacle.

Question 5 — Correct: C

Correct Answer: Plan a supported real-world attempt and review the result against the agreed criterion before deciding

Explanation: The termination criterion calls for generalization outside the counseling setting, which role-play accuracy alone has not demonstrated. A planned attempt supplies relevant evidence without making weekly treatment indefinite.

Question 6 — Correct: A

Correct Answer: The client will implement and track a consistent routine during the three weekly parenting nights for one month

Explanation: This objective is measurable and limited to conditions the client can control. Requiring another household's participation without agreement is not attainable, while delay would overlook meaningful action already available.

Question 7 — Correct: B

Correct Answer: Include client-chosen coping and advocacy options while recognizing discrimination as a relevant stressor

Explanation: The client's report identifies discrimination as an important contextual factor and asks for choice about practical responses. Ignoring that context or requiring a formal complaint would reproduce the lack of collaboration the client experienced previously.

Question 8 — Correct: B

Correct Answer: Center the current grief and sleep concerns while retaining relevant ADHD supports if they affect goal attainment

Explanation: Treatment planning should address current client needs while recognizing established conditions that may influence implementation. Making stable ADHD the first target or ignoring it completely would each overstate the role of the diagnosis.

Question 9 — Correct: B

Correct Answer: Use approved secure contacts to confirm each client's location and needs, then arrange proportionate alternatives and crisis access

Explanation: A disaster can change both location and service need, so individualized secure contact supports appropriate triage and alternatives. A message identifying the full caseload would expose private information, while waiting could leave clients without access.

Question 10 — Correct: C

Correct Answer: Clarify the new need and collaboratively decide whether to open a revised episode of care or arrange another resource

Explanation: Completion of the original goals supports ending that treatment episode, but the new concern deserves appropriate clarification and planning. Automatic termination or automatic extension would bypass assessment of the bereavement need, service fit, and client preference.

Question 11 — Correct: B

Correct Answer: The client will attend two gardening-club meetings within four weeks and record one interaction after each

Explanation: The objective defines an observable behavior, frequency, time frame, and simple monitoring method tied to the client's interest. The broad friendship statement is not measurable, while the counselor-action statement is an intervention rather than a client objective.

Question 12 — Correct: B

Correct Answer: Begin with a modest parenting objective, track energy use, and schedule review of readiness for the education goal

Explanation: The plan follows the client's immediate value while respecting the energy limit that made simultaneous full-intensity goals unsustainable. Tracking and a scheduled review preserve the education goal rather than treating prioritization as permanent abandonment.

Question 13 — Correct: B

Correct Answer: Rewrite the goal in clear shared language and add observable signs of pausing before responding

Explanation: The client can state a meaningful target, allowing the counselor to preserve clinical precision in understandable, collaborative language. Technical wording is not inherently superior if it obscures the client's goal.

Question 14 — Correct: A

Correct Answer: Close the obsolete objective and collaboratively establish goals that address the transition and current priorities

Explanation: The external change makes the supervisor-conflict objective irrelevant while introducing new concerns that may warrant treatment. Revising the plan preserves responsiveness rather than retaining a nonfunctional target or assuming all need has ended.

Question 15 — Correct: B

Correct Answer: Schedule focused sessions while ashore and create offline practice and support plans for each voyage

Explanation: This format uses the client's predictable availability and the resources that remain feasible at sea. Requiring unreliable private video access or postponing all care would fail to adapt the plan to a stable occupational constraint.

Question 16 — Correct: B

Correct Answer: The team defines shared outcomes, provider roles, communication permissions, and a lead coordination responsibility

Explanation: Clear roles and an identified coordination function reduce contradictory or duplicated work while preserving authorized collaboration. Independent plans or client-carried messages leave responsibility fragmented.

Question 17 — Correct: B

Correct Answer: Identify specific volunteer behaviors, a self-monitoring method, and criteria for contacting a counselor if avoidance increases

Explanation: The plan transfers group learning into a chosen community setting and provides both monitoring and a defined response if difficulty returns. Delaying practice or requiring the former leader's presence would not support independent generalization.

Question 18 — Correct: C

Correct Answer: Encourage timely medical evaluation while continuing to address the client's counseling goals and coordinating with permission

Explanation: The sleep-related symptoms and limited response warrant medical evaluation, while the facts do not require counseling to stop. Concurrent care allows relevant medical findings to inform the plan without assuming that the mood concern is either entirely medical or entirely psychological.

Question 19 — Correct: A

Correct Answer: Identify interim supports and responsibilities, specify necessary information exchange, and set criteria or a date for resuming care

Explanation: A temporary interruption requires clarity about who will address needs during the pause and how regular care will restart. Immediate closure or informal responsibility creates avoidable ambiguity and potential gaps.

Question 20 — Correct: A

Correct Answer: Help confirm a timely prescriber appointment, provide urgent-care options, and continue counseling within scope

Explanation: The imminent clinic closure and limited medication supply require prompt linkage to a qualified prescriber, not medication advice from the counselor. Counseling can continue within scope while the concurrent service transition is arranged.

Question 21 — Correct: C

Correct Answer: Gradually thin the token schedule, strengthen natural reinforcement, and continue monitoring the routine

Explanation: Sustained improvement and reduced prompting support a planned fading process rather than abrupt removal or permanent dependence on tokens. Continued monitoring shows whether the more natural contingencies maintain the routine.

Question 22 — Correct: C

Correct Answer: Combine gradual sleep and caffeine objectives with appropriate panic treatment and ongoing symptom tracking

Explanation: The assessment supports several interacting contributors rather than a single complete explanation. Addressing modifiable sleep and stimulant factors alongside panic-focused care permits the plan to test change without ignoring symptoms that occur independently.

Question 23 — Correct: C

Correct Answer: Use brief scheduled starts, track relief and later anxiety, and reinforce completion of defined sections

Explanation: The plan directly targets the short-term relief that maintains avoidance and replaces an overwhelming task with observable approach behavior. Insight alone has not changed the pattern, while requiring the entire packet at once may intensify avoidance.

Question 24 — Correct: C

Correct Answer: Review the requested information with the client and update the authorization if the client agrees

Explanation: The existing permission covers attendance information, not the added clinical details. Discussing the request and revising authorization if desired allows useful coordination while preserving the client's control over scope.

Question 25 — Correct: A

Correct Answer: Translate the barrier into a change in sequencing, support, access, or intervention when relevant

Explanation: Identified barriers are planning data that can guide feasible modifications and supports. They do not automatically prove resistance or make the underlying goal inappropriate.

Question 26 — Correct: A

Correct Answer: Confirm that telephone care remains suitable, update remote-session procedures, and use it while transportation alternatives are explored

Explanation: The client has reliable private telephone access, and policy permits that format when suitable. A temporary modality change maintains treatment while the transportation barrier is addressed rather than forcing a public setting or unnecessary pause.
